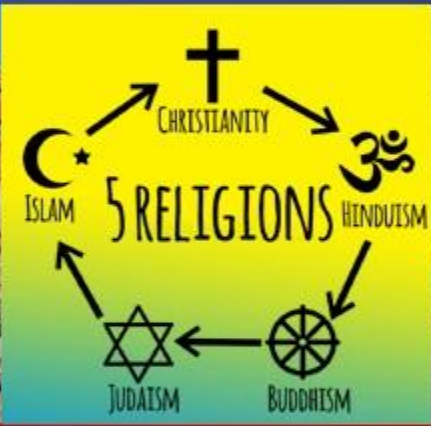


ART & CULTURE

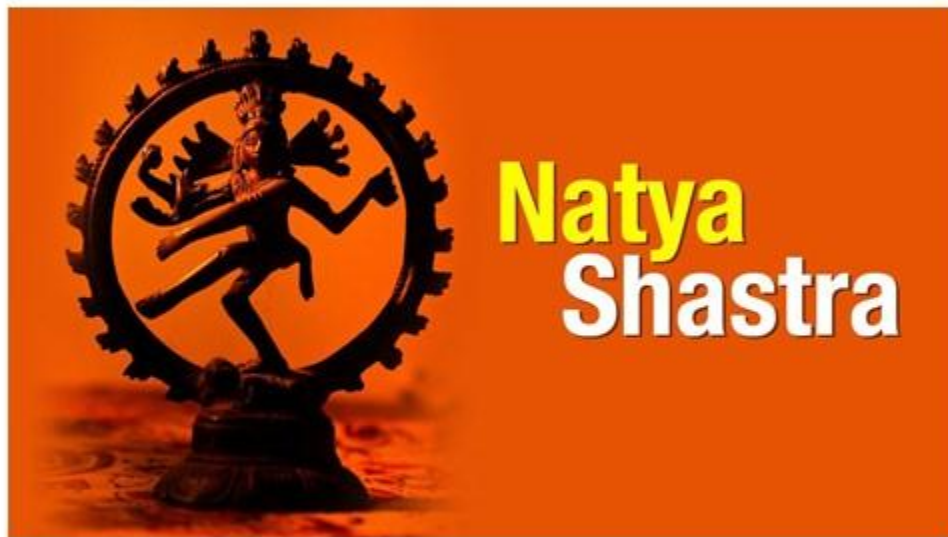


INDIAN THEATRE

MODULE - 2

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT
THEATRE

INDIAN THEATRE AND ITS ORIGIN



- 1 The tradition of theatre in India has a history of thousands of years.

- 2 The earliest reference to Sanskrit drama is found in the works of **Panini** in the 4th – 5th century BCE and later in Mahabhashya of **Patanjali** in the 2nd -1st century BCE.

- 3 Theatre and its various forms are also documented in the **Natya Shastra** by **Bharata** (200 BCE to 200 CE), which considered theatre to be composed of dance, music, and acting.

- 4 The Natya Shastra describes the various types of theatre and also documents various aspects of theatre such as **acting, dance, music, dramatic construction, costumes, makeup, props, etc.**

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE AND ITS FEATURES



- 1 The ancient Indian literature is replete with a wide variety of Sanskrit plays written by eminent dramatists such as **Ashvaghosha**, **Kalidasa**, **Bhasa**, **Sudraka**, **Bhavabhuti**, and others.
- 2 Traditionally, 10 different types of Sanskrit plays were identified.
- 3 Amongst these, the **Nataka** and **Prakarana** were two play types which were emphasised upon, particularly in the **Natya Shastra**.

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE AND ITS FEATURES

WHAT ARE THE FEATURES OF CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE?

- 1 The Sanskrit theatre was traditionally performed on sacred grounds such as in temple and its courtyards and later on in palaces.
- 2 Its objective was to educate as well as entertain the people.
- 3 As a form of art, it was bound by certain rules and traditions.
- 4 For example, a sutradhar (holder of strings) who was like a stage manager/ director was considered integral to the play.
- 5 Invocation of God and pre-play rituals (Purvaranga, comprising music and dance) at the beginning of the theatrical performance was another salient element.
- 6 The theatre itself could employ male as well as female actors or both.
- 7 But certain types of sentiments and characters were considered better suited for either male or female and hence, there was a **typecasting of roles to a certain degree**.

INDIAN THEATRE

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE AND ITS FEATURES

SANSKRIT PLAYS FOLLOW ALMOST RITUALISTIC PROGRESSION



Curtains were used to intensify the impact of play.

- 1 The play started with a number of pre-play rituals, also known as **purva-ranga**, most of which were performed behind the curtain.
- 2 Following this, the **Sutradhar**, who was the stage manager and director, entered the stage with his assistants.
- 3 Dressed in white, he would offer worship to the deity and seek his blessings.

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE
AND ITS FEATURES

SANSKRIT PLAYS FOLLOW ALMOST RITUALISTIC PROGRESSION

4 He also announces the time and place of the play. He also gave a brief introduction of the playwright.

5 The stages were mostly two-storeyed. While the upper floor was used for representing celestial sphere, the lower one represented the terrestrial sphere.

- 6 Classical Sanskrit play was bound by some rigid conventions:
- They were generally four to seven-act plays.
 - They mostly had happy-endings. Portrayal of tragedy was almost rare.
 - The protagonist would always achieve the object of his desire at the end.
 - The plays had well defined opening, progression, development, pause and conclusion.

INDIAN THEATRE

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE AND ITS FEATURES

DECLINE OF THE SANSKRIT THEATRE



- 1 Sanskrit theatre though quite popular in the 1st millennia, suffered a decline thereafter.

- 2 This was due to lack of royal patronage, diminishing significance of Sanskrit as a mass language, and languages like Prakrit becoming popular.

- 3 Further, the orthodoxy of the Sanskrit theatre also restricted the creative manoeuvrability of the playwrights.

- 4 With the advent of the Islamic regime, Sanskrit theatre suffered a further decline and remained alive only in a few pockets of the Country.

SOME IMPORTANT SANSKRIT PLAYS AND PLAYWRIGHTS

1

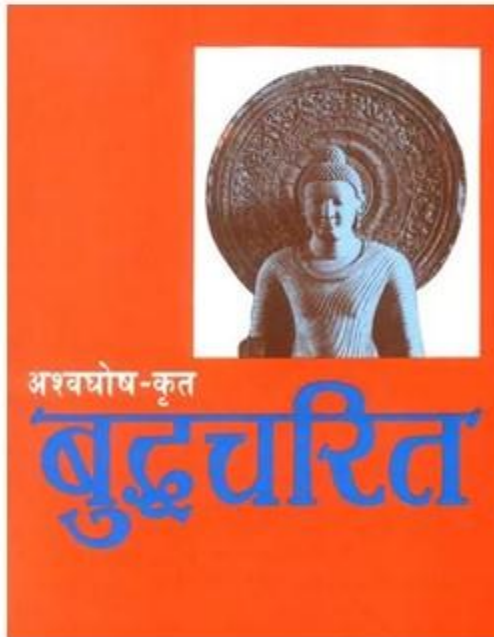
ASHVAGHOSHA

1

Considered as one of the pioneers of Sanskrit drama.

2

Composed **Sariputra-Prakarana** in nine acts. (better known for his work **Buddha Charita**)



IMPORTANT SANSKRIT PLAYS AND PLAYWRIGHTS

2

BHASA

Svapnavāsavadatta of Bhāsa



- 1 Credited with having written 13 plays which were lost for centuries and discovered later (which were being used in Koodiyattam)
- 2 Kalidasa (5th century CE) in *Malavikagnimitram* refers to Bhasa as a celebrated dramatist and so does *Rajashekhara*, the famous poet of 9th century CE.
- 3 Composed *Swapna-Vasavadatta* (the dream of Vasavadatta), a romantic drama of Vatsa king Udayana and Vasavadatta, the daughter of the ruler of Avanti.

IMPORTANT SANSKRIT PLAYS AND PLAYWRIGHTS

3

SUDRAKA

The Mṛichchhakatika of Śūdraka



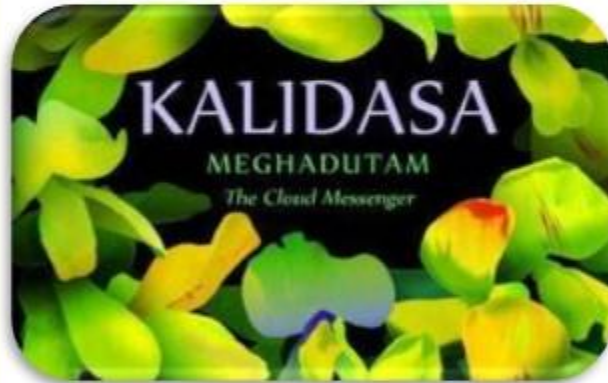
- 1 His most famous play being **Mricchakatika** (The Little Clay Cart), the story of Charudatta, an impoverished Brahmin who falls in love with a courtesan Vasant Sena who is being pursued by somebody else.
- 2 The play explores various emotions of love, humour, villainy , deceit, and intrigue.

IMPORTANT SANSKRIT PLAYS AND PLAYWRIGHTS

4

KALIDASA

MĀLAVIKĀGNIMITRAM
OF KĀLIDĀSA



His Meghadutam (poem), Raghuvamsa (epic poem), and Kumar Sambhava (epic poem) are some of his other exemplary works.

1

One of the most famous playwrights and litterateur whose work **Abhijnan-Shakuntalam**, **Malavikagnimitram**, and **Vikramorvasiyam** are considered to be masterpieces and the best examples of Sanskrit plays.

2

While **Malavikagnimitram** is the story of King Agnimitra's love with exiled servant Malavika, **Vikramorvasiyam** is another love story of mortal king Pururava with celestial nymph Urvashi.

IMPORTANT SANSKRIT PLAYS AND PLAYWRIGHTS

4

KALIDASA



A play of Kalidasa's Abhijnanashakuntalam

3

Abhijnana- Shakuntalam is a story of king Dushyant's marriage to Shakuntala, daughter of a sage, their separation, and later the king forgetting about her, and how he eventually recalls her and accepts her as his wife.

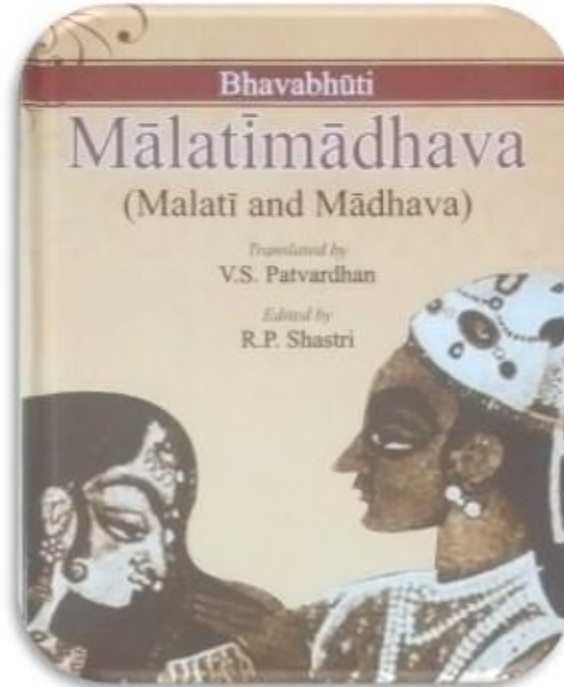
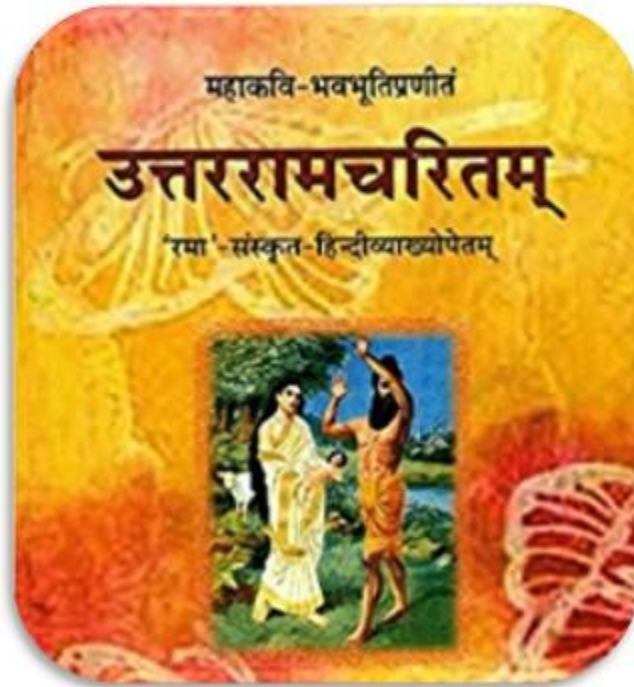
4

Kalidasa was also a court poet in the court of Gupta kings.

IMPORTANT SANSKRIT PLAYS AND PLAYWRIGHTS

5

BHAVABHUTI



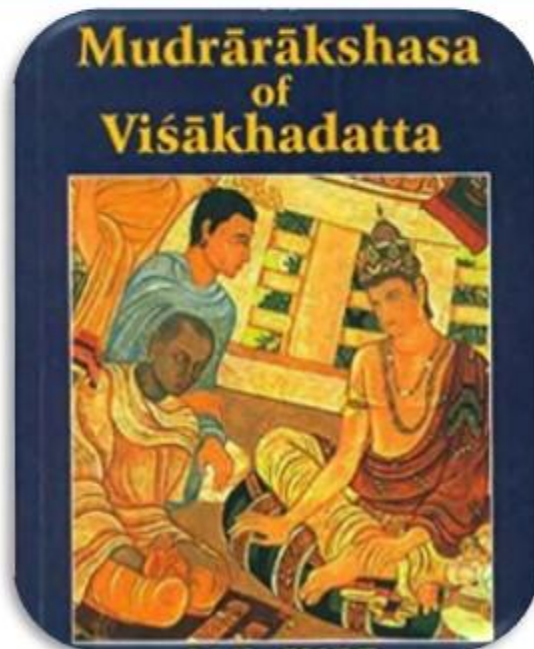
- 1 Composed **Mahavira-charita** (early life of Rama) and **Uttar-Ramacharita** (later life of Rama).
- 2 Another of his famous play is **Malati-Madhava** (based on the romance of Malati and Madhava).
- 3 He was a court poet in the court of king Yashovarman of Kannauj.

IMPORTANT SANSKRIT PLAYS AND PLAYWRIGHTS

6

VISHAKHADATTA

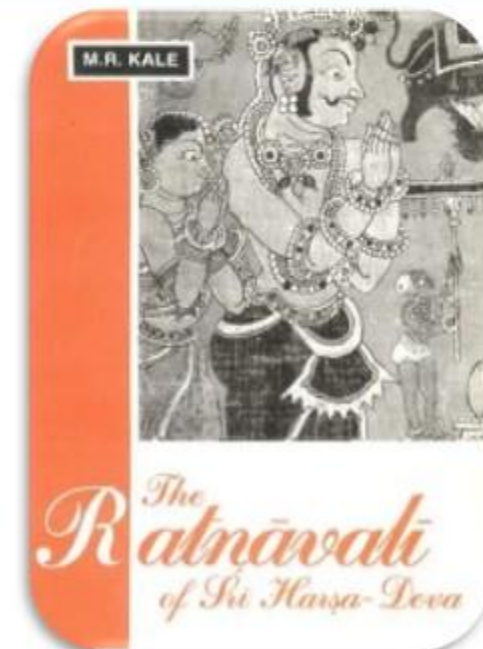
A famous poet and playwright who composed the famous plays **Mudrarakshasa** (about ascent of Chandra Gupta Maurya) and **Devi Chandraguptam**.



7

HARSHAVARDHANA

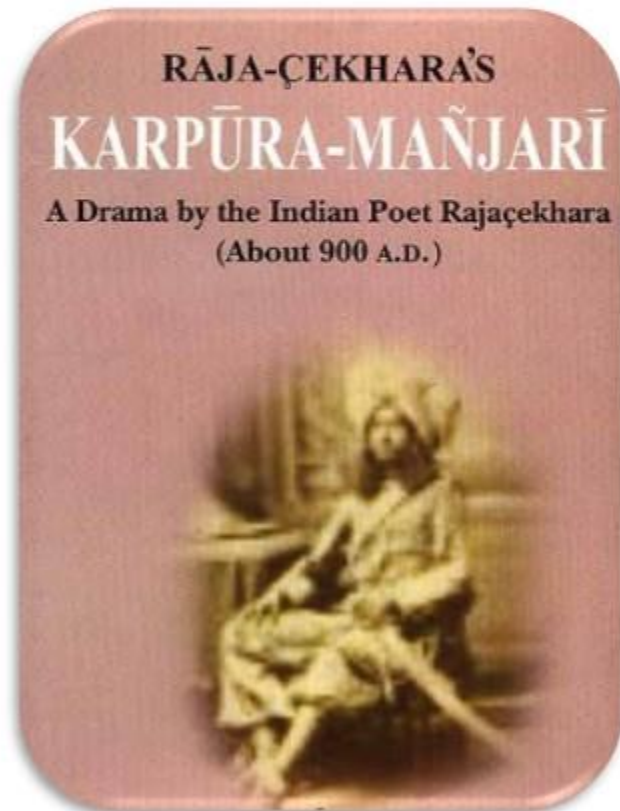
The great India emperor is credited with having written the plays **Ratnavali**, **Priyadarsika**, and the Buddhist drama **Nagananda**.



IMPORTANT SANSKRIT PLAYS AND PLAYWRIGHTS

8

RAJASHEKHARA



1

An eminent poet and playwright who was also a court poet of Gurjara Pratiharas

2

He wrote the famous play of Karpuramanjari.

INDIAN THEATRE

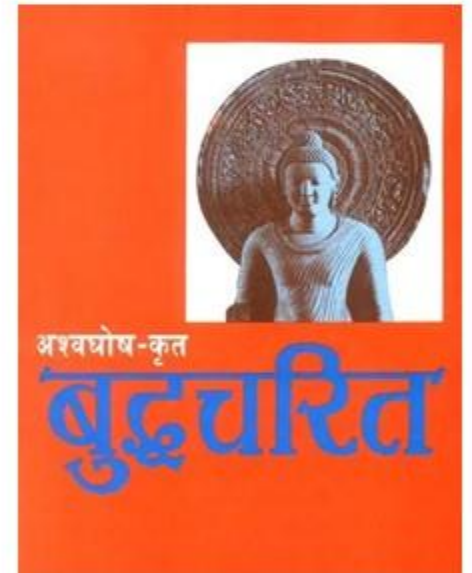
CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE

FEATURES OF CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE

SOME RULES FOLLOWED IN SANSKRIT THEATRE

IMPORTANT SANSKRIT PLAYWRIGHTS AND THEIR PLAYS

DECLINE OF SANSKRIT THEATRE



INDIAN THEATRE

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE

KOODIYATTAM



- 1 Koodiyattam (Kudiyattam) is India's oldest continuing form of theatre that has survived since 10th century A.D. in Kerala.
- 2 It completely adheres to the rules laid down in Natya Shastra and is the traditional privilege of the Chakyar and Nambiar castes of Kerala.

INDIAN THEATRE

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE

KOODIYATTAM

- 3 The play is performed in Sanskrit, Prakrit and Malayalam, with **Mizhavu** and **Edakka** providing the background music.



Mizhavu



Edakka



Artists playing the Mizhavu

INDIAN THEATRE

CLASSICAL SANSKRIT THEATRE

KOODIYATTAM



Margi Madhu Chakyar performing Koodiyattam

- 4 All the character begin the play with **Nirvahana**, a recollection of the past events of the story.
- 5 After this, the story unfolds in a leisurely fashion with commentaries on social, philosophical and political behaviour.
- 6 Margi Madhu Chakyar is a leading exponent of this art form.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE



- 1 India boasts of a rich tradition of folk theatre in various parts of India.
- 2 The traditional folk theatre reflects the various aspects of the local lifestyle including social norms, beliefs and customs.
- 3 While the Sanskrit theatre was more urban-oriented and sophisticated in its treatment of the play, folk theatre had rural roots and the rustic flavor was reflected in the dramatic style involved.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE



- 4 Most of the folk theatres that still exist, emerged in the period around 15th-16th century A.D. with **devotional themes**.
- 5 However, with time it started adopting **love ballads and accounts of local heroes** and thus adopted more secular tones.
- 6 In the post-independence period, the folk theatre became more popular **method of dissemination of social wisdom** than mere social entertainment.
- 7 Indian Folk Theatre can be broadly classified into three categories as follow:

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

RITUAL THEATRE

- Ankia Nat
- Kala
- Ramlila
- Raslila
- Bhuta

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

- Bhavai
 - Daskathia
 - Garodas
 - Jatra
 - Kariyila
 - Maanch
 - Nautanki
- Swang
 - Tamasha
 - Villu Pattu
 - Oja-Pali
 - Pandavani
 - Powada

SOUTH INDIAN THEATRE

- Yakshagana
- Burra Katha
- Pagati Veshalu
- Bayalata
- Tal-Maddale
- Theyyam
- Krishna Attam
- Kuruvanji

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